



USER GUIDE · PART 02

Takeoff

Measure quantities straight off your PDF plans

Takeoff

Takeoff is where you measure quantities straight off a PDF plan — counts, lengths, and areas — so you never scale a drawing by hand again. It's the heart of Fieldscale, and everything you measure here can flow into an estimate.

New here? Take the tour.

Open Takeoff and click the  **Tutorial** button in the top toolbar. It spotlights each button on the real screen and walks you through the steps below. It also runs automatically the first time you open Takeoff.

The 7-step flow

- 1 **Open or create a project.** Click  **Projects** and choose **+ New Project**. Each project holds one plan set.
- 2 **Load your plan.** Upload a PDF. A multi-page set loads every sheet — flip between them with the page arrows at the bottom.
- 3 **Set the scale first.** This is the most important step. Either **Calibrate** (draw a line over a known dimension and type its real length) or pick a listed scale like 1/4" = 1'. Nothing measures correctly until this is done.
- 4 **Add what you're measuring.** Click **+ Add** to create an item — a wall, a line, an area, or a count — and give it a name, color, and unit.
- 5 **Draw on the plan.** Use the tool rail on the left to count symbols, click points for lengths, or trace shapes for areas.
- 6 **Check your quantities.** Everything tallies live in the Quantities panel on the right.
- 7 **Finish up.** Roll totals into a Summary or a Materials order, then export — or send the quantities into an estimate.

Setting the scale (do this first)

Every measurement depends on the scale being right. You have two ways to set it, both on the top toolbar:

Calibrate (on the tool rail)

Draw a line along something whose real length you know — a dimension line, a standard door, a grid spacing — then type that length. Fieldscale works out the scale from it. Best when the printed

scale is unknown or the PDF was resized.

Pick a scale (the scale button)

If the sheet states its scale, choose it from the list and hit Apply. You can also **apply one scale to every sheet at once** if the whole set is drawn the same.

Auto-detect scale

Fieldscale can try to read the scale from the sheet for you as a starting point.

Wrong numbers? Check the scale.

If a measurement looks off by a lot, the scale is almost always the cause. Re-calibrate against a known dimension on that exact sheet — scale can differ from sheet to sheet.

The takeoff tools (left rail)

Select

The default. Click a measurement to move, copy, or delete it.

Pan

Slide the sheet around. You can also hold the Space bar or drag with the middle mouse button anytime.

Calibrate

Set the scale from a known length (see above).

Quick Measure

Measure a distance on the fly without adding it to your takeoff — just to check something.

Arc / curve

Measure a curved run by clicking three points (start, a point on the curve, end). It's added as a curved linear length.

Highlight

Shade a region of the sheet to mark it up.

Find Similar

Draw a box around **one** symbol — a door, outlet, or light — and Fieldscale finds and counts all the matching ones on that sheet. A huge time-saver on repetitive counts.

Verify

Step through every count on the sheet one by one, check off the good ones, and delete strays.

Search sheets

Search text across every sheet (see below).

Markup

Add text, arrows, boxes, lines, and ellipses for notes and clouds.

Ask AI

Ask questions about the plans in the AI Assist panel.

Adding and organizing items

Click **+ Add** to create a takeoff item. You choose its type — **count** (each), **linear** (length, like wall or trim), or **area** (square footage) — and give it a name, color, and unit. From then on, measuring with that item drops into the Quantities list.

Quantities panel

Every measurement tallies here live, with running totals. The item counter at the top shows how many items you have.

Folders

Group related items with **+ Folder** — e.g. by room or by scope.

By trade / by folder

Switch how the list is grouped so it reads the way you think.

This sheet / all sheets

Toggle between just what's on the current sheet and totals across the whole set.

Working across many sheets

Search all sheets

Type a word — "door", "outlet", a detail number — and every matching sheet appears with a hit count. Jump straight to matches, step through them, or highlight them all on a sheet.

Reference tags

Right-click a detail callout to add a tag that jumps to the referenced sheet, so you can chase a detail without hunting.

Add reference PDFs

Attach extra PDFs (specs, cut sheets) to search alongside the plans.

Compare

Overlay one sheet against another version and highlight exactly what changed between revisions — added shown one color, removed another.

Straighten

Rotate or square up a crooked scan.

Turning measurements into output

Summary

Totals rolled up by trade / CSI division, as a printable report.

Materials

Turns your measurements into a material order list — bags, sheets, squares, yards, studs — with waste built in.

Export CSV

Send the quantities to a spreadsheet.

Save Sheet

Save the current sheet as an image with your measurements, highlights, and markups drawn on.

Export Plan Set

Export every sheet as one PDF, with your measurements drawn on each page.

Teamwork and versions

Takeoff layers

Two people can take off the same plans as separate layers. Switch whose view you're seeing, then **Combine** the layers when you're done.

Save & autosave

Work autosaves as you go; a dot appears when there are unsaved changes. You can also save manually.

Earlier versions

Restore a previous saved version if you need to back up — and restoring itself is undoable.

Lock takeoff (bid set)

Lock a finished takeoff so the numbers you bid from can't be changed by accident.

Revise a plan set

When new drawings come in, start a revision (slip-sheeting) to bring them in cleanly.

From Takeoff to money

Your quantities don't stop here — pull them into the Estimating section to put prices against them and build a proposal. See Part 04 · Estimating.